

EmpowerED

Phonics Auction — Teacher Guide

Age group	Grade 1–5
Class size	Any
Time	15–30 min
Materials	None

Overview

Phonics Auction turns phonics practice into a strategy game where teams bid on how many words they can correctly name from a chosen category. Teams compete by raising the bid higher and higher before one team challenges the other to prove it. The game builds confidence, teamwork, listening skills, and fast phonics recall.

Setup

1. Split the class into 2 teams
2. No materials needed — this is a speaking game
3. Teacher chooses the phonics category before each round
4. Start with easier categories students already know
5. Teacher acts as the auction host and controls the bidding

How to Play

1. Teacher announces a phonics category: Example: '-at family'
2. Team 1 starts the bidding by saying how many words they can name
3. Team 2 can either raise the bid or say 'Challenge!'
4. Bidding continues until one team challenges the other
5. The winning team must correctly say the number of words they bid
6. Students cannot repeat words or hesitate for more than 5 seconds
7. If the team succeeds, they win the round
8. If the team fails, the opposing team steals the point

Scoring

Auction result	Points awarded	Outcome
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Successful bid	1 point	Team wins round
Failed bid	0 points	Other team steals point
Correct challenge	1 point	Challenge successful
Wrong/no answer	0 points	Bid fails

Example Auction

Teacher says	Teams respond
'-at family'	Team A: 'We can say 4'
	Team B: 'We can say 6'
	Team A: 'Challenge!'
	Team B: cat, bat, hat, mat, rat, sat
	Successful bid — Team B wins point

Volunteer Tips

1. Keep bidding fast to maintain excitement
2. Encourage teams to discuss strategy quietly before bidding
3. Celebrate successful challenges loudly
4. Start with easy categories before introducing harder phonics patterns
5. Use dramatic countdowns during answer rounds
6. Do not allow repeated words

Differentiation

For beginners: Use only simple word families and allow students extra thinking time before counting down.

For advanced students: Introduce harder categories like blends, digraphs, Magic E, or mixed phonics rounds.

Phonics Categories Quick Reference

Category	Example words
-at	cat, bat, hat, mat
-og	dog, fog, log, jog
Magic E	cape, kite, hope
OO words	moon, spoon, book

Blends	frog, brick, slide
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